

Message in a Bottle

Eight gatherings. One city. Nobody gets to own the people inside it.



For Savage Worlds Adventure Edition
Campaign by Austen Tucker-Crowder



Requires the SWADE core rules. Unofficial, unplaytested fan edition. AI assistance disclosed in the credits.

Start here

Chicago has had ten quiet years. Your old crew has a friend to bring home, a portal to assemble, and a perfectly reasonable expectation that this will be the strangest part of the evening.

It will not be the strangest part of the evening.

Message in a Bottle is an eight-gathering campaign for **Savage Worlds Adventure Edition (SWADE)**. It starts with a playable reunion and ends with a voyage between realities. Between them: cartoon physics, a corrupt municipal contractor, cosmic property law, and a Chicago whose residents have never been told what contains their city.

Audience: Game Masters. Full campaign spoilers. Give players only the separate player handouts, and reveal the later handouts when their scene arrives.

Requirements: The SWADE core rules, dice, Action Cards, Bennies, and three to five players with characters. The core rules are not included. This is an original fan adventure, not an official Pinnacle product. No Companion is required. It works best with a group willing to treat absurd things seriously enough to save the people inside them.

Recommended baseline: Four Seasoned Wild Cards, eight gatherings of roughly three to four hours. Give one Advance after Sessions 1, 3, and 5. If you import powerful characters from an older campaign, keep their identities and agree their SWADE builds before play. These are choices for this edition, not recovered facts about the original game.

Status: Free fan edition 0.1. Written and mechanically checked; not playtested. Encounter counts and challenge targets are starting points. After your first session, adjust pressure rather than changing an NPC's numbers secretly in the middle of a roll.

What changed for this edition

The campaign bible established eight gatherings, Chicago's ownership mystery, the Vivarium Keeper, the accelerator, the timed passages, and the homecoming. It deliberately left maps, NPC builds, several mechanics, and alternate endings open.

This edition adds runnable scenes, original NPC profiles, explicit clues, a node map, adventure-specific clocks, a fictional accelerator site, three travel stops, handouts, and failure routes. It chooses a fictional mayor named **Calder**, a generic returning hero named **Mark**, and the Keeper's **repossessor** as its field agent. These additions are preparation for a new table. They do not rewrite the old campaign's history or supply player decisions that never happened.

The sea and archipelago imagery comes from Austen Tucker-Crowder's *The Witch Who Sold the World*, whose universe is distinct from the *Ink and Paint* books. This campaign is an intentional tabletop remix, not a canonical sequel. All cartoon people here are original; use no licensed cartoon cameos.

Human-directed AI tools assisted development, writing, assembly, and illustrations. The images interpret campaign plans. They are not recovered maps or records of played sessions.

Before people arrive

1. Read **The secret in one minute**, Session 0, and the NPC profiles.
2. Decide whether Mark is a player's character or a supporting NPC. A player controls their own character. If Mark is an NPC, he supplies the fiction of electrical navigation, not automatic solutions or bonus turns for the GM.
3. Ask each player for a place in Chicago worth saving and one remembered adventure image. Memories are proposals: confirm them together before adding them to continuity. New groups can invent those memories openly.
4. Agree boundaries around disaster, coercion, cruelty, and confinement. This campaign depicts people treated as property; it rejects that treatment. Check whether the group wants that theme. Revise or remove distressing descriptions freely.
5. Pick a pause signal, allow breaks, and establish that a player can step away without explaining. Use public fictional intake questions, never publish personal answers.
6. Print the reunion sheet. Keep the other handouts behind the screen until their scenes arrive. Put a copy of SWADE's Support, Tests, Dramatic Tasks, Quick Encounters, and combat sections within reach.

The secret in one minute

Up was a higher-dimensional accountant who kept small realities as living collections. Up died in a stupid accident. He was not murdered. His collection went to an estate auction.

A human municipal contractor, Calder, found scavenged auction technology. A human could not bid, so an eligible higher-dimensional buyer acted for him. Its compensation was Chicago as a living snow globe, including permission to shake it. Calder gained political power and a profitable disaster-repair business. The Keeper gained entertainment.

The heroes experience the shakes as unrelated weirdness. They discover the business pattern, enter the Thompson Center's dimensional bureaucracy, find the bottle's seam, and use a fictional accelerator to crack the ownership boundary. Chicago need not fly away: the heroes are thrown outside while the city remains where it is.

The final two gatherings are a voyage through a primordial archipelago. The heroes send a message, find their city, and return without rebuilding the boundary. The intended ending is simple: Chicago belongs to its people.

Run the mystery without a gate

Essential clues are available when characters take a sensible action. A failed roll changes time, exposure, witnesses, or detail; it does not erase the only path forward. Roll for risk and uncertainty, not to decide whether the campaign continues.

Track the following revelations. Deliver each through at least two routes before asking players to act on it:

Revelation	First route	Backup route
Incursions are patterned	Matching contractor seals	Witness sees equipment before a shake
Somebody profits	Emergency invoices	Crew testimony and replacement stock
Chicago is contained property	Ownership diagram	Auction receipt translated by a clerk
A buyer was paid with shaking rights	Keeper's enclosure label	Compensation clause in the ledger
The seam can be cracked	Thompson control diagram	Repossessor's repair instructions
Travel windows are timed	Mark's portal story	Three-pulse countdown on the vessel
Homecoming must not restore ownership	Severance receipt	Keeper offers an explicit bad bargain

Checks, clocks, and core rules

Use SWADE normally for Trait rolls, Support, Tests, combat, damage, Bennies, and Dramatic Task complications. This book refers to those rules; it does not reproduce their text. An unlisted skill is not an automatic rejection: let the player describe a method, then choose a suitable Trait and a consequence.

Adventure clocks are new procedures for this module. They are not extra SWADE rules. Draw the stated number of boxes. Fill a box only at the trigger the scene gives you. Tell the players what is worsening. A roll failure does not fill two clocks unless the scene explicitly

says so.

For multi-person Dramatic Tasks, use the stated token goal and duration with the core rules. Any eligible character may work, Support another character, or handle the surrounding threat. Do not count a Support roll as its own Task Token. The generous opening is a tutorial; the accelerator demands trade-offs. If the group has three heroes, reduce group token targets by two; with five heroes, increase them by two. Leave deadlines unchanged. These targets are this edition's calibration choices.

Cartoon physics, without a new subsystem

Describe impossible physics, then resolve a concrete action with the core rules. A painted door is an exit if a character establishes why this scene's rules allow it. A dropped anvil is a hazard, not permission to ignore damage. A squashed person can be rescued; the injury still matters.

Before a roll, say what the character expects, what rule is currently strange, and what a failure will cost. Let characters learn that rule through observation or a harmless test. Never secretly change it to negate a clever plan. Cooperative rescue earns allies; cruelty loses them. Cartoons are people.

Adjust at the table

For newer players, reduce the number of simultaneous enemies and introduce one rule at a time. For stronger parties, add an endangered location, a second objective, or a competing deadline before adding damage. Keep enemy retreats and negotiation available.

Each gathering includes an exit condition and a failure route. Stop on a revelation if the group is tired. Session numbers describe a useful spine, not a rule that nobody may investigate ahead or return to a place. Use the printable session checklist or the GM runner's Used marks to remember what actually happened.

Session 0 - Bring Mark Back

Act I - The city slips. Bring the crew together and teach SWADE through an urgent shared job.

Opening

The portal frame is taller than the garage door. Its cables are labeled in handwriting you recognize. Through the empty center, someone knocks three times. A voice says: "I found the exit. Please tell me you found the entrance."

Essential clues

- Mark crossed passages that opened on a schedule.
- Somewhere outside, living worlds are kept as collections. Mark remembers a label, not an explanation.

Visible clock: Portal instability

3 boxes. Fill one box at the end of a task round while the portal remains unfinished. **At the limit:** Mark arrives with collateral trouble. The return is never cancelled.

1. Agree the return

Offer: Ask each player what their hero contributes and what they want Mark to find waiting.

Let the crew examine the frame and choose three feeds: power, alignment, and physical stability. No roll is needed to discover these jobs. A successful Notice, Electronics, or Repair roll spots a scorched label and allows the group to choose where the first complication appears. Give new players one ordinary roll before introducing the larger task.

Clue: A strip of tape says: "Keep an anchor at both ends. Do not wait for the third pulse."

2. Build the portal

Offer: Open the core Dramatic Task reference. Offer power, alignment, bracing, or Support.

Tutorial task: 8 group Task Tokens in 3 rounds. Electronics or Repair operates a feed; Athletics braces the frame; a convincing alternative uses the appropriate Trait. Run Action Cards and complications using SWADE. In round 2, two rift leeches attach to exposed feeds. A player can remove, lure, or fight them, or Support someone doing it. Explain each rule at the moment it becomes useful. Do not require every character to possess technical skills.

Clue: The feed display counts three pulses between neighboring realities.

3. Let the first mistake matter

Offer: Bring Mark through. Ask the players which thing they protect when the portal kicks.

On success, Mark arrives and the crew secures the frame. If the goal is missed or the task ends early, he still arrives; choose one cost with the players: the frame is ruined, a leech remains loose, or a harmless but unsettling patch of wrong weather follows him. Use a brief combat with remaining leeches only if the group wants that tutorial. Mark describes contradictory corridors and a hard departure window. He knows nothing about Calder's purchase.

Clue: Time windows and current can guide a route, but neither supplies a destination.

Outcomes

Success: Mark returns; the working frame can later supply a spare anchor.

Partial success: Mark returns with one chosen cost. Record it and make it visible in Session 1.

Failure route: Mark returns after a destructive kick. The crew salvages the route notebook and continues. An injured or Incapacitated hero is handled with core rules and care; failure does not erase their agency.

Before the next gathering

Spend the next gathering with the Chicago the crew wanted to come home to. End this one on reunion, not the ownership explanation.

Session 1 - Chicago Is Safe

Act I - The city slips. Make the ten quiet years matter before reality becomes visibly unreliable.

Opening

The city looks like home. The train arrives when the sign says it will. A shopkeeper knows your order. Then a street name changes while you are looking at it, and everybody else seems certain it was always that way.

Essential clues

- Continuity errors cluster near newly installed weatherization panels.
- At least one witness remembers the change. Public records insist nothing changed.

1. Visit something worth saving

Offer: Use a place the players chose on their reunion sheets.

Invite each player to introduce one local person, then confirm the invention with the group. Mark can tell one fragment from his route without a lore monologue. Use Persuasion, Common Knowledge, or Research only when a character takes a risk or wants privileged access. Ordinary friendly conversation succeeds without dice. Introduce contractor stickers on replacement panels as scenery.

Clue: The same contractor seal appears on two apparently unrelated repairs.

2. One harmless error, then one costly error

Offer: Change a sign; then let a crossing briefly lead to the wrong platform.

Give the group an obvious observation first: the station announcement names a street that nobody agrees about. Next, one civilian is stranded on a platform visible through an impossible doorway. A cooperative rescue uses one suitable Trait roll per participating hero or a core Quick Encounter. A failed roll costs the crew a broken tool, attention from security, or extra time; the civilian remains reachable through a mundane service exit. Never require a roll to notice the doorway.

Clue: The civilian saw the panel crew working before the error began.

3. The first undeniable cartoon

Offer: Introduce Pip, an original toon-bodied person, carrying a painted umbrella.

Pip steps through the platform door. Their shadow takes a moment to catch up. They are frightened, capable of explaining their own needs, and not an enemy. Ask whether the crew offers shelter, containment, investigation, or an escort. Each is a valid next action. A failed Persuasion roll makes Pip cautious; food, patience, or a trusted witness earns a second conversation without another required check.

Clue: Pip's neighborhood is real too. Its physical rules were separate until the shaking began.

Outcomes

Success: The crew has a witness, an ally, and a panel seal to investigate.

Partial success: The cartoon arrival is witnessed publicly. Contractors can identify the crew; Pip still offers the essential information.

Failure route: The crew loses Pip in the confusion. Pip leaves the umbrella and a route mark; a civilian witness can lead them to the next incursion.

Before the next gathering

Give the crew its first Advance. Ask how it prepares for another overlap, then bring the cartoon gathering to a chosen neighborhood.

Session 2 - Ink and Paint

Act I - The city slips. Make coalescence tangible through rescue, containment, and conflicting physical rules.

Opening

A bus brakes for a painted crosswalk. The crosswalk lifts off the road like a ribbon. On one side, people run as if gravity has stopped listening. On the other, people are still expecting gravity to work.

Essential clues

- Calder Restoration delivered specialized replacement panels before the incident.
- A Thompson environmental-control routing mark is on the dispatch sheet.

Visible clock: Public danger

6 boxes. Fill one box when a rescue round ends with nobody addressing civilians. **At the limit:** A second group becomes stranded. Rescue remains possible; ask which group the heroes reach first.

1. Establish the local physics

Offer: Show one reversible oddity before anyone risks their life.

A ladder can bend without breaking, a painted door opens onto the other side of the same wall, and falling objects hang for one heartbeat before dropping. Keep those three rules consistent for the encounter. Let harmless testing establish them without rolls. A risky crossing uses Athletics, a suitable technical skill, or a player's creative proposal. Announce a failed crossing's cost before the roll; an ally or alternate door prevents an instant dead end.

Clue: Pip recognizes the neighborhood as a real place, not a hallucination or invading army.

2. Save the people on both sides

Offer: Offer three jobs: anchor the bus, open an escape route, and hold the unstable boundary.

Rescue task: 8 group Task Tokens in 4 rounds. Use appropriate Athletics, Electronics, Repair, or Persuasion actions; Persuasion can organize panicking people, not command physics. A falling-sign hazard occurs once in round 2: tell everyone beneath it first, then allow an Agility roll to get clear; failure deals 2d6 damage. Heroes who move civilians out of that area prevent it without damage rolls. Contractors arrive to seize Pip, one per hero. They prefer restraint and can be persuaded that evacuation outranks their order.

Clue: A contractor says, "They told us what would be damaged before the first call came in."

3. Follow the cleanup

Offer: Put Handout 2 in front of the group.

The dispatch paper is automatically available from an abandoned kit, a cooperative worker, or a supervisor's public notice. Research verifies the order timing; a raise names a second matching job. A failure still confirms the before-and-after sequence but attracts Calder's attention. Helping the contractors get home makes a crew contact available later. Defeating them yields the same paper, without the ally.

Clue: The job is profitable, predicted, and connected to Thompson.

Outcomes

Success: Civilians escape and the boundary stabilizes. Pip or a contractor volunteers evidence.

Partial success: Choose damaged property or a stranded civilian group. The crew gets the dispatch paper and can mount a second rescue.

Failure route: A larger rescue is needed, not an erased population. A witness carries the paper to the crew. Record which people need help and move the investigation forward.

Before the next gathering

The players now know who profits. Let them choose the first investigative route in Session 3.

Session 3 - Shake the Snow Globe

Act II - Somebody owns this place. Turn separate emergencies into an acquisition mystery without betting it on one roll.

Opening

The repair invoice is routine. Same company. Same surcharge. Same “unexpected” emergency. The delivery time is the strange part: the replacement supplies arrived before the city knew anything was broken.

Essential clues

- The municipal business profits from predicted shakes.
- An external owner can move the city’s boundary; the human beneficiary is not the eligible bidder.

1. Offer three ways into the pattern

Offer: Records desk, repair depot, or incursion witness. Let the group choose.

At the records desk, Inez shares public invoices; Research adds the matching shell account. At the depot, workers share the kit schedule; Stealth or Persuasion secures a private manifest. At the witness site, someone points out the equipment that pulsed just before the air changed; Electronics explains its connection to Thompson. Each route supplies the core pattern automatically. Failed rolls cost access, time, or discretion. Use contractors only if a confrontation develops; they are witnesses as well as obstacles.

Clue: Three incidents share an equipment serial and a Thompson control destination.

2. Show the hand outside

Offer: A window reflection shows the whole skyline tilted in a curved glass wall.

An announced shake gives the crew a short rescue or observation choice. A hero who protects someone gets a clear view of the external shape; another can secure the equipment. Use an ordinary roll for either risky action. No roll is needed to understand that

the event is deliberate. A failed observation still leaves a recording from a witness, but the crew is identified by the control network.

Clue: The incident is someone exercising a privilege, not a machine breaking at random.

3. Confront the beneficiary

Offer: Calder offers a job before he offers a threat.

He says the city needs someone who can arrange reliable recovery. If exposed, he attempts to reach Thompson, where normal jurisdiction fails. Do not give him an automatic escape: capture, negotiation, surrender, or defeat are valid. If the players capture him, his key and the records direct them to Thompson anyway. If he dies, a deputy contractor has the routing order. A core Social Conflict or a short chase can resolve opposition; the result changes his leverage, not whether the maze exists.

Clue: Calder says someone else did the bidding and expects to be paid in "enrichment."

Outcomes

Success: The crew secures the key or a cooperative guide and enters Thompson with leverage.

Partial success: Calder reaches Thompson first. The party has the destination and records, but custodians expect them.

Failure route: The crew is publicly blamed for a disruption. Inez supplies a service entrance and proof. That accusation is fictional fallout; it cannot remove every action the players can take.

Before the next gathering

Give the second milestone Advance. Keep Calder's fate and the workers' loyalties when preparing the maze.

Session 4 - The Thompson Center Maze

Act II - Somebody owns this place. Make the location reveal the purchase, the shaking rights, and a way to break the boundary.

Opening

The ticket says your number will be called shortly. It has been printed on a leaf, a boarding pass, and a municipal parking citation. Across the atrium, three offices occupy the same door. All three say you need the other office first.

Essential clues

- Up died accidentally; his estate auction sold the inhabited holding.
- The Keeper's compensation includes shaking rights.
- The control seam can be cracked by a tuned beam without relocating Chicago.

Visible clock: Maze shift

4 boxes. Fill one box for a repeated route without a changed method, or a delay the crew knowingly accepts. **At the limit:** Custodians arrive, one per two heroes rounded up. Other routes remain open.

1. Choose a route through jurisdiction

Offer: Use the node map. Start at A and visibly offer B or C.

Calder's key admits the crew to one node without a roll. At B, an elven departures queue contains stranded travelers; helping them gains a transit badge and a route to D. At C, Inez or an estate clerk provides the ledger. A roll can speed either route or preserve discretion. Failure fills the shift clock once and opens the other route. Never send the party back to the start as its only consequence. Security can be persuaded, bypassed, or fought.

Clue: The bidder's name and the beneficiary's name occupy different columns.

2. Make the deal legible

Offer: Reveal Handout 3. Answer questions plainly.

An eligible higher-dimensional Keeper bid for Calder. The arrangement gave the Keeper Chicago as a living snow globe. Up's death was a stupid accident; there is no murder solution hiding behind it. Research or Persuasion can discover a severance record or an enforcement weakness, but the central facts need no roll. If the crew tries a legal cancellation, let it suspend one shake or free one custodian. Complete invalidation of ownership still requires reaching the seam in this edition.

Clue: A person's presence in a ledger does not make the ownership legitimate.

3. Choose what to disable

Offer: At D, offer the shake switch or the path to Calder. At E, offer the seam diagram.

Electronics or Repair disables a local shake feed; a creative physical bypass can work too. Success prevents the first extra hazard at the accelerator. Failure costs a tool or brings a custodian; the seam diagram remains readable. It names the fictional Loop Resonance Works, and a clear note distinguishes cracking the ownership boundary from moving the city. A surviving Calder can bargain, surrender the key, or be escorted out. Keep choices about him in the players' hands.

Clue: The heroes may be flung outside when the boundary breaks. Chicago can remain in Chicago.

Outcomes

Success: The party has the diagram, route, and one disabled feed or allied custodian.

Partial success: They have the route but must evacuate people or bring Calder with them.

Failure route: They escape through a service passage with the essential diagram. Pursuit costs them the easy accelerator entrance; it does not hide the objective.

Before the next gathering

Ask who they want to protect when they fire. Prepare the accelerator around that choice.

Session 5 - Crack the Bottle

Act II - Somebody owns this place. Give the whole party simultaneous jobs while freeing the city from ownership.

Opening

The control display shows a seam through the city, but the line belongs to something larger than the map. The engineer points to three feeds. "Power. Aim. Containment. You can get two wrong and still make a terrible noise."

Essential clues

- The seam and the earthquake are different problems.
- A correct shot severs ownership; the city does not have to leave its physical place.

Visible clock: Earthquake

6 boxes. Fill one box after each activation round. Add one extra only for an explicitly announced containment mishap. **At the limit:** A ground hazard strikes and evacuation becomes urgent. The team can still fire.

1. Reach the fictional test hall

Offer: Use Loop Resonance Works, a fictional installation. Show three feeds and two exits.

Dr. Vale can explain the fantasy physics, but does not operate every station for the heroes. There is no real accelerator schematic or real-world firing procedure here. The group chooses power, calibration, containment, evacuation, and protection. An allied custodian holds an entrance; an allied contractor opens an exit. If the crew disabled Thompson's shake feed, the first hazard is only a warning. Otherwise a falling panel threatens the service route: announce it and allow Athletics or Repair to protect that route.

Clue: The beam targets a higher-dimensional ownership seam, not residents or a real geological weapon.

2. Activate under pressure

Offer: Use a Dramatic Task alongside initiative for interference.

Group goal: 12 Task Tokens in 4 rounds. Electronics calibrates or energizes; Repair contains; Athletics braces; Persuasion organizes evacuation. Each action needs a concrete job. Support works normally and does not itself earn tokens. Two rift leeches interfere in round 2; contractors equal to half the heroes, rounded up, arrive in round 3 unless an ally or agreement keeps them away. Fill one earthquake box after each round. Announce a containment mishap before a risky attempt; a Critical Failure on that attempt adds one extra box as well as the core task consequence. Apply other core complications normally.

Clue: The seam display opens a channel out of the bottle as calibration approaches its goal.

3. Choose a cost and let the world open

Offer: At the task's end, resolve the seam and quake separately.

If the goal is reached, the seam cracks. If not, allow one clearly offered emergency firing: it cracks the seam at the cost of damaging the hall and filling the earthquake clock. A crew that refuses can evacuate, regroup, and retry with a portable salvaged feed; this costs a scene, not a new campaign. At six quake boxes, everyone in an exposed area gets one announced Agility roll to reach cover; failure deals 2d6 damage. A successful evacuation action protects the civilians automatically. The boundary then throws the heroes onto a service platform outside. The city remains where it belongs.

Clue: An auction service plate on the platform can become a vessel and a route instrument.

Outcomes

Success: Chicago is freed; the heroes reach the archipelago with a stable vessel component.

Partial success: The city is freed with repair needs or missing equipment. Allies evacuate survivors; the voyage has an extra repair beat.

Failure route: An emergency firing or second attempt frees the city at a severe local cost. If the party declines both, use the retreat and retry route. Do not narrate them into an action they refused.

Before the next gathering

Give the third milestone Advance. Describe the primordial sea and let the players name their improvised vessel.

Session 6 - Adrift in the Universe

Act III - Adrift, then home. Teach timed crossings while making outside realities into places with people.

Opening

The platform floats above a foggy sea. Far away, a school, a wood, and a lit train carriage drift on separate horizons. Your route instrument pulses once. Mark stops talking. "We have until the third one."

Essential clues

- Every useful slide has a brief window and needs an anchor at both ends.
- A home signal can use a chosen Chicago place as its address.

Visible clock: Slide departure

6 boxes. Fill one box after each meaningful travel beat or local choice, not after each individual roll. **At the limit:** The window closes. Wait for the next one with a cost, or use another island route.

1. Build a way to travel

Offer: Turn the auction platform into a skiff, ferry, or other group-chosen vessel.

Establish a power source, a steerable surface, and a route instrument. Each needs one suitable successful Trait roll, with Support welcome. A failure adds a repair beat and a chosen limitation, not destruction. Mark can energize a compatible component while a hero navigates or repairs; another electrical or mechanical method works if he is absent. Reveal Handout 4. The foggy sea is fantastical; do not impose realistic cryogenic lethality on this adapted novel imagery.

Clue: A place the players named in Session 0 is recognizable as a destination signal.

2. Choose two stops, not a tour checklist

Offer: Offer the stranded train, elven departures, and the auction dock. The crew chooses its route.

At the train, saving passengers costs two beats and earns a signal lamp; leaving costs one and leaves an ally unresolved. At departures, two custodians demand a badge; negotiation, showing the ledger, or a short fight earns a route stamp. At the dock, an abandoned lot offers spare anchors; searching costs a beat, and the reposessor can offer a shortcut in exchange for a future ownership claim. Let players reject it. Each local problem uses one or two ordinary rolls or a core Quick Encounter. Reset the slide clock when arriving at a new stop.

Clue: The lamp, stamp, or anchor identifies a home route. Any one supplies the essential direction; two make the finale's first calibration easier.

3. Leave before the slide closes

Offer: Show six boxes and state the current departure pressure.

Crossing uses one navigation roll and one anchoring roll, with suitable skills and Support. Success and failure change the crossing's cost. At six boxes, the current window closes: wait for the next cycle and add a repair or rescue problem, or go by the other offered route. If both anchors are lost, the crew is marooned between realities; a visible drifting cable can be caught with Athletics, or an ally can pull them to a nearby island. No single failed roll ends the voyage. End when they know the home signal and see the final route.

Clue: Getting home must not reconstruct the city's enclosure.

Outcomes

Success: The crew has a clear home signal and two helpful preparations.

Partial success: They have the signal with damaged gear or an ally to return for. Preserve that promise for the epilogue.

Failure route: A missed slide changes the route. They recover at another island, obtain the signal from a beacon, and begin Session 7 with one repair beat.

Before the next gathering

Ask what message the crew wants Chicago to hear. Make it the centerpiece of the final gathering.

Session 7 - Message in a Bottle

Act III - Adrift, then home. Pay off the voyage and the electrical motif without returning the city to captivity.

Opening

The city answers your signal. There are people at the other end, not a glass wall. A second voice interrupts: "We can make your passage quite safe. All we need is the old boundary."

Essential clues

- The Keeper's safe passage bargain would restore ownership.
- The tether is a mechanism the heroes can disable, not an invincible monster to defeat.

Visible clock: Final tether

4 boxes. Fill one box after a finale round while the tether remains active. **At the limit:** The repossessor boards. Disabling the tether remains available.

1. Make home recognize them

Offer: Ask each hero for one line of the message and one contribution to the crossing.

The route requires the group's chosen place name and three long flashes plus one short. Electronics, Repair, Persuasion, or a justified other skill can send, stabilize, or coordinate the signal. If the crew gained two preparations in Session 6, give +1 to the first calibration attempt. If Mark is a player, let that player choose the electrical contribution; if he is an NPC, he supplies current while the heroes make the decisions. Missing gear can be replaced with a visible cable and one repair beat.

Clue: Residents on the other side can anchor the destination without enclosing it.

2. Resist the last claim

Offer: The repossessor attaches a visible tether. Put its target terminal within reach.

The agent offers safe passage for a renewed boundary, then attempts enforcement if refused. Use its original profile. The heroes may fight, bargain for time, demonstrate the severance, or disable the tether with Electronics or Repair at -2. The terminal has Toughness 6 and can be broken; no need to kill the agent. The task to align and cross requires 8 group Task Tokens in 3 rounds using core rules. A hero who addresses the tether has a clear competing job; Support counts normally. Fill the four-box tether clock only while the anchor remains attached.

Clue: The agent's legal assumption can be rejected; the city's people are not valid collateral.

3. Resolve the crossing, then listen

Offer: Use the crew's actual choices to determine the ending.

Goal met with tether disabled: return freely. Goal met with tether active: the bow crosses but the vessel remains held; residents help stabilize it while the heroes take one last scene to sever the terminal or force a release. Goal missed: the final window closes, leaving an anchored island and a new cycle; accept a damaged vessel or a delayed homecoming, then try again after a concrete repair. A crew that accepts the bad bargain gets a compromised ending, with the ownership problem explicitly unresolved. Do not call that freedom. At home, ask each player for one changed relationship and one place they visit first.

Clue: The intended victory is freedom plus homecoming. A warm welcome cannot hide a renewed cage.

Outcomes

Success: Chicago is safe because it belongs to its people. The heroes return, and residents publicly acknowledge what they did.

Partial success: The city is free; the heroes return later or with damage, and keep a promise to rescue an ally. Give them a route to honor it.

Failure route: They remain temporarily anchored outside, or knowingly accept the Keeper's bargain. State the cost honestly. Offer the repair-and-retry route; never turn one unlucky roll into an unannounced total-party death.

Before the next gathering

Close on player epilogues. Record which places, people, and promises survived. Ask what should change before anyone calls this edition playtested.

NPC profiles

All profiles below are original builds for this edition. Attributes, skills, Pace, Parry, and Toughness use SWADE conventions. **Wild Card** and **Extra** are rules labels; use the core book for how each works. Unlisted skills use the core unskilled procedure. Damage marked **Str+d4** or **Str+d6** uses the character's Strength die. Armor is included in Toughness and shown in parentheses. Listed gear is deliberately simple; substitute equipment from your own core book when appropriate.

Mark, returning hero - Wild Card

Use only if Mark is not a player character. He is glad to be home, frightened of going back outside, and unwilling to treat the displaced as disposable.

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d8, Spirit d8, Strength d6, Vigor d6. **Skills:** Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d6, Electronics d8, Fighting d4, Notice d6, Persuasion d6, Repair d6, Stealth d4. **Pace:** 6. **Parry:** 4. **Toughness:** 5. **Hindrances:** Loyal. **Edges:** None. **Gear:** A scorched coat, insulated tools, a pocket notebook; improvised tool, Str+d4.

Navigation fiction: Mark can feed his electrical current into a compatible device. This is not a general combat power or a new Arcane Background. Roll his Electronics when he operates that device. He can Support; he cannot replace a player's action. If a player wants a fully powered Mark, agree a core-rules character build and Trappings separately. No proprietary power text is included here.

Contractor, security operative - Extra

A worker following an emergency contract, not automatically a murderer. Most surrender or retreat when abandoned. A persuaded crew may become an ally.

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d6, Vigor d6. **Skills:** Athletics d6, Fighting d6, Notice d6, Persuasion d4, Repair d6, Shooting d6, Stealth d4. **Pace:** 6. **Parry:** 5. **Toughness:** 6 (1). **Hindrances/Edges:** None. **Gear:** Protective vest, Armor 1; tool baton, Str+d4; insulated net, use a core grappling or improvised restraint resolution. No firearm is required for any scene in this campaign.

Custodian, dimensional security - Extra

A person paid to protect a jurisdiction they only partly understand. Their priority is their own exit route, then their assigned checkpoint.

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d6, Spirit d4, Strength d8, Vigor d8. **Skills:** Athletics d6, Fighting d6, Intimidation d6, Notice d6, Repair d4. **Pace:** 6. **Parry:** 5. **Toughness:** 8 (2). **Hindrances/Edges:** None. **Gear:** Protective coat, Armor 2; heavy baton, Str+d4; transit

badge. **Tactic:** Guard an exit, warn once, and withdraw if the contract is visibly cancelled. Persuasion or a convincing forged order can end the encounter without fighting.

Rift leech - Extra

An original creature resembling a wasp assembled from electrical insulation. Treat its tangled cable mass as Size 0 for this profile. It feeds on current, not on moral alignment. A spare battery can draw it away.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4 (animal), Spirit d6, Strength d4, Vigor d4. **Skills:** Athletics d8, Fighting d6, Notice d6, Stealth d8. **Pace:** 6 (flight). **Parry:** 5. **Toughness:** 4.

Hindrances/Edges: None. **Gear:** None. **Attack:** Bite, Str+d4. **Custom ability:** While a leech is attached to a live cable, that feed cannot contribute to a task. An adjacent character may remove it with a successful Athletics or Repair roll as an action, or lure it away with another live source without a roll. It has no unexplained immunity or copied creature abilities.

Calder, fictional mayor - Wild Card

This is a fictional antagonist, not a claim about a real politician or family. He wants ordinary status and unlimited control over the disasters that make him look useful.

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d8, Spirit d8, Strength d6, Vigor d6. **Skills:** Athletics d4, Common Knowledge d8, Electronics d6, Fighting d4, Intimidation d6, Notice d6, Persuasion d8, Repair d6, Research d6, Stealth d4. **Pace:** 6. **Parry:** 4. **Toughness:** 5. **Hindrances:** Greedy (Major). **Edges:** None. **Gear:** Auction key, emergency procurement book, portable radio; improvised briefcase attack, Str+d4. **Tactic:** Offer jobs, invoke procedure, retreat behind contractors. He is not a super-powered combat boss.

The reposessor - Wild Card

The Keeper's field agent. Courteous, precise, and incapable of seeing a resident as anything but inventory until someone makes that assumption costly.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d10, Spirit d8, Strength d6, Vigor d8. **Skills:** Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d8, Electronics d8, Fighting d8, Intimidation d8, Notice d8, Persuasion d8, Repair d6, Research d8, Stealth d6. **Pace:** 6. **Parry:** 6. **Toughness:** 8 (2).

Hindrances/Edges: None. **Gear:** Boundary coat, Armor 2; tuning rod, Str+d6; a portable jurisdiction stamp.

Custom jurisdiction anchor: The rod sustains one visible tether attached to the vessel. An adjacent hero can disable it with Electronics or Repair at -2, break the exposed terminal (Toughness 6), or get the agent to release it. Disabling the tether does not require defeating the agent. The agent is not immune to ordinary combat or Tests. It leaves if the boundary is severed and it has no defensible contract.

Allies and the Keeper

The records clerk **Inez**, cartoon resident **Pip**, and engineer **Dr. Vale** are original supporting names for this edition. Give an ally d6 in a relevant skill when a roll is needed; they supply access, context, or a single Support action, not Task Tokens on behalf of an absent player. Pip does not have to be comic relief.

The Vivarium Keeper is a remote antagonist. Do not give it a huge combat profile and turn the ending into a fight with an unkillable creature. Its actions arrive through a shake, a contract, a tether, or an agent: specific things the heroes can confront. Its baseline is a collector who calls danger enrichment. If your table prefers the Cruel Naturalist or the Spectator, change the voice and motive, not the established clues or shaking rights.

Table reference

The Thompson Center node map

This is a fictional encounter map, not a plan of the real building. Each connection takes one scene transition; do not measure a real pedestrian route.

Node	Exits	Question or pressure
A - Ticket hall	B, C	Whose jurisdiction is this?
B - Elven departures	A, D	Save stranded travelers or accept a shortcut?
C - Municipal records	A, D	Who is paid, and who is named as owner?
D - Weatherization floor	B, C, E	Disable the shake controls or follow Calder?
E - Control seam	D; accelerator route	What do the heroes need to free the city?

A closed route always has the other listed route. A clerk can redirect a lost group to C. The maze's shift clock creates a cost, not an infinite random walk. The GM runner tracks scene completion independently of clock pressure.

Pressure ledger

Clock	Boxes	Fill a box when	At the limit
Portal instability	3	A full tutorial task round ends below the goal	Mark arrives with collateral trouble
Public danger	6	A rescue round ends with nobody addressing civilians	Another group needs rescue; do not silently kill them
Maze shift	4	The group repeats a route without changing method, or accepts a listed delay	Custodians arrive; the exit remains reachable
Earthquake	6	An accelerator round ends; add one extra on a stated containment mishap	Ground hazard and evacuation; firing remains possible
Slide departure	6	A travel beat finishes, including rescue or repairs	Window closes; use the missed-window route
Final tether	4	A finale task round ends while the tether remains	The agent boards; keep the final objective available

These are manual scene clocks, not actual-minute timers. The runner's session timer is a pacing aid and does not fill them automatically.

Encounter scaling and review

Start with one contractor per hero in scenes that call for contractors; use half that many custodians, rounded up, when a threat also shares a timer. Add the reposessor only at the finale. Never add every possible enemy from the appendix to one scene.

Run one dry pass before inviting a table: follow the clues without rolls, take the failure exit from the portal, skip one travel window, and end with the tether intact. The campaign must still have a next action in every case. That structural check is not a playtest. Damage balance, actual pacing, and the emotional effect of the ending require people playing.

Between gatherings

- Write down the revealed clues, chosen costs, surviving allies, and one thing a player made true.
- Ask what destination or investigation the group wants next. Prepare it before filling in an unrelated branch.
- Record any content adjustment privately. Player personal disclosures do not belong in the public module or source repository.

- Advance only at the agreed milestones. Update encounters for the characters' actual capabilities.
- Keep the next session's opening, immediate objective, essential clue, and two exit states within reach.

Credits, source boundaries, and fan notice

Campaign conception and direction: **Austen Tucker-Crowder**. This free module was expanded from the current Message in a Bottle campaign bible and eight unplayed session outlines, reviewed October 9, 2026. New mechanics and supporting names are identified as additions for this edition. No private player questionnaire, correspondence, real-person backstory, Dread scenario text, Dread audio, or Pinnacle rulebook text is bundled here.

The GM runner takes its practical format from the author's **Dread at the Wooden Shoe GM guide**: a clear control room, scene cards, printable reference, manual cues, and local progress. Its clocks, guidance, and campaign content are newly adapted for this campaign; it does not use Dread's resolution system.

Illustrations: existing human-directed AI interpretations from the campaign walkthrough. Text and production: developed with human-directed AI assistance. This edition is offered free without a signup or payment requirement. The SWADE core rulebook remains a separate requirement.

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Message in a Bottle

Scene Director's Handbook

24 scenes · step-by-step GM procedures · full spoilers · unplaytested fan edition



Campaign by Austen Tucker-Crowder. Requires the separately available Savage Worlds Adventure Edition core rules. Not official Pinnacle material.

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A practical, scene-by-scene running guide for *Message in a Bottle*

GM eyes only. Every page contains spoilers. This is a companion to the full adventure, not a replacement for the scene statistics, maps, core SWADE rules, or player handouts. The PDF release appends this handbook to the original illustrated GM book. The standalone handbook is useful as a separate screen or printout.

Edition: Free Fan Edition 0.1, expanded GM guidance; written and mechanically checked, **not playtested**.

Guidance below explains how to run the established 24 scenes without dictating player choices. If a suggested example conflicts with a player's established action, keep their action and use the scene's essential clue and outcome to improvise forward.

The five-minute GM briefing

- **Prep for a gathering:** Read its three scenes, essential clues, and outcome states in the main book. Put the next player handout face down. Jot the names and current attitude of Mark, Pip, Inez, Calder, and any living allies who matter. Prepare SWADE Action Cards, Bennies, three blank clock tracks, and the stat blocks indicated by that gathering.
- **Open:** Read the gathering's boxed introduction in the main book, or paraphrase it. Ask *one* concrete question about what the heroes are doing right now. Don't narrate their feelings or put decisions in their mouths.
- **Run each scene:** (1) Name the visible problem. (2) Give two obvious approaches and allow a third. (3) State the stake and the consequence *before* asking for a roll. (4) Resolve with the main book's listed Trait check, Quick Encounter, Dramatic Task, or Social Conflict. (5) Deliver the essential clue even when the roll fails. (6) End with a decision that points to the next scene.
- **Use SWADE normally:** The ordinary Trait target is 4 unless the core rules or the encounter specify otherwise. Raises matter; failure creates a cost, new pressure, or an opponent's move. Bennies, Support, Tests, Action Cards, Wounds, and Incapacitation work as in the core book. These notes are not replacement rules.
- **Protect agency:** The clues are guaranteed; the advantages aren't. Never require success on Research to learn a fact essential to the only way forward. Don't decide Calder escapes, that the party fires, or that the final bargain is rejected. The final scene responds to choices.
- **Use safety tools:** Before play, ask privately about boundaries around abduction, confinement, memory changes, displacement, civic disaster, and physical danger. Agree on a pause/rewind method. Don't demand a public explanation for a boundary. Check in when the city is shaken or citizens are described as property.
- **Pace:** Treat the times below as flexible targets for a 3–4-hour gathering. A scene can be shortened to its clue and one consequential choice if the table is running late. Never turn a 20-minute action into a one-hour search for a mandatory clue.

Session 0: Bring Mark Back

Before play: Decide with the table whether Mark is a player-controlled hero or the listed support NPC. Put an empty three-box Portal Instability clock and an eight-token/three-round Dramatic Task tracker where everyone can see them. Have two rift leech profiles ready. **Suggested pacing:** reunion and plan 25–40 minutes; portal task 50–70; aftermath and bonds 25–40; character setup takes the remaining time. **Do not reveal** the auction, Calder, or the Keeper yet.

0A. Agree the return (0-plan)

Set the table: A garage-sized frame stands between exposed cables. Mark knocks from the other side. The crew can study power, alignment, and bracing without a roll. **Say:** "You have a return signal, a frame, and maybe three pulses before the window shifts. What does each of you take charge of?"

1. Ask each player to name a job, a piece of familiar equipment, or someone they brought to help. Write the choices down; they become useful props later.
2. Describe the scorched tape in plain view: *Keep an anchor at both ends. Do not wait for the third pulse.* Offer Notice, Electronics, or Repair if someone wants to learn *why* it burned. On a success, let them choose which feed will be safer when the next complication hits. On failure, they still read the warning.
3. Ask what they want Mark to find waiting at home. Keep the answer for the Chicago scenes.

If they hesitate: Point at the three leads: power, alignment, bracing. **If they skip planning:** Move directly to the first task round; a rushed feed becomes the first complication. **End when:** Everybody has a job and a personal reason to bring Mark home.

0B. Build the portal (0-build)

Set the table: Draw three feeds and put the 8-token/3-round goal beside them. **Say:** "The return window opens. You can get Mark through, but something will have to hold the frame together."

1. Start the SWADE Dramatic Task and deal Action Cards according to the core rules. Let players describe a specific contribution before choosing Electronics, Repair, Athletics, or another justified Trait. Support and nontechnical solutions are welcome.
2. After every incomplete round, fill one Portal Instability box. In round two, put **two rift leeches** on exposed cables. Explain visibly that attached leeches stop that feed contributing. A hero may lure a leech with a battery without a roll, remove it with Athletics/Repair, or fight it using the appendix stat block.
3. Count tokens openly. Introduce task complications only when their card/rule calls for them. Announce the result after round three; do not secretly add a fourth round to force success.

On a miss: The task changes the damage and loss, not whether Mark returns. **If someone ignores the feed:** A leech steals power until dealt with; any other feed remains usable. **End when:** The window surges and Mark appears.

0C. Let the first mistake matter (0-return)

Set the table: The frame buckles; Mark has one foot in Chicago. **Say:** "You can save the machine, keep the creatures contained, or protect everyone nearby. Which matters most?"

1. Apply task success or failure from 0B. On success, the frame survives. Otherwise let the group choose or see one cost: broken frame, escaped leech, or a localized wrong-weather patch.
2. Offer one brief remaining-leech fight *only if* the crew wants it. Keep danger recoverable and allow surrender, containment, or retreat.
3. Let Mark speak as a frightened friend, not a plot encyclopedia. He remembers timed crossings and a label suggesting inhabited worlds were in a collection, but cannot name the collector or explain Calder.

If Mark is a PC: Ask that player what they remember; offer only the established route facts. **If everyone is injured:** Treat injuries under SWADE; let an ally help with shelter and recovery rather than cancel the campaign. **End when:** Someone welcomes Mark home; ask where the group will meet again.

Session 1: Chicago Is Safe

Before play: Revisit the places named in Session 0 and the chosen portal cost. Prepare a contractor seal, one ordinary local witness, Pip, and a small map of a public transit location. **Pacing:** homecoming 35–50; reality errors and rescue 45–60; Pip 30–45; conversation and Advance afterward. Deliver the first Advance at the end.

1A. Visit something worth saving (1-home)

Set the table: Return to a restaurant, stoop, arcade, train stop, or other place a player invented. **Say:** "Everything is almost exactly as you left it. Who recognizes you here?"

1. Go around the table once: ask each player for a local person, sensory detail, and the smallest thing that's changed in ten years.
2. Make friendly NPC conversation free. Call for Persuasion, Common Knowledge, or Research only if a hero seeks privileged information or risks offense. Mark can contribute one incomplete travel memory, never the whole mystery.
3. Show the same restoration contractor seal on two separate repaired surfaces. Let the players photograph or copy it without rolling.

If they leave quickly: Bring the second seal into the street ahead of them. **If they chase the company immediately:** Give them a public address, not the whole conspiracy. **End when:** The table names at least one piece of Chicago worth saving and notices an odd repetition.

1B. One harmless error, then one costly error (1-error)

Set the table: A transit announcement contradicts a street sign, then an impossible doorway reveals a stranded rider. **Say:** "The platform is just a few steps away, except the steps lead somewhere they didn't a moment ago."

1. Describe the contradiction clearly; do not ask for Notice to see it. The witness also remembers the old sign, though records don't.
2. Present a rescue choice: cross, direct the rider to the service exit, or coordinate transit staff. Use one suitable Trait check per risky approach or a short core Quick Encounter.
3. Before each roll name the cost: lost equipment, security attention, or delay. On a failed roll keep the rider reachable through the ordinary exit.

If the group argues the geometry: Agree one consistent passage rule for this scene and let them test it. **If they refuse the rescue:** The rider gets out with transit workers and tells them about the panel crew. **End when:** The witness or evidence points to weatherization panels.

1C. The first undeniable cartoon (1-cartoon)

Set the table: Pip, a living toon-bodied resident, enters carrying a painted umbrella; their shadow arrives late. **Say:** "I'm not supposed to be on this side. Please don't send me back until I know it's safe."

1. Ask whether the heroes shelter, escort, question, or contain Pip. Make Pip an informed person with preferences, never a punchline.
2. Let patient conversation establish that Pip's neighborhood is real and had different physics before the shaking. If trust is strained, Persuasion can help. Failed Persuasion makes Pip cautious, not silent forever.
3. Give the crew a practical next step: identify who installed the panels before the incursion. Record whether Pip is an ally, a wary witness, or has fled.

If Pip flees: Leave the painted umbrella, route mark, and a civilian who saw the departure. **If heroes threaten Pip:** Show the consequences to trust, while preserving the route clue. **End when:** The crew agrees what it will do about the next overlap.

Session 2: Ink and Paint

Before play: Draw three hazards: bus, exit corridor, shifting boundary. Prepare an 8-token/4-round rescue task, a six-box Public Danger clock, and one contractor Extra per hero. Stage Handout 2 face down. **Pacing:** physics 30; rescue 60–90; evidence and fallout 35–50.

2A. Establish the local physics (2-rules)

Set the table: A painted crosswalk peels off the road, separating two terrified groups. **Say:** "The door is painted on. It still opens. A falling sign stops in midair for a heartbeat before dropping."

1. Establish three repeatable local rules: elastic ladder, painted door connecting opposite sides of one wall, delayed falling objects. Demonstrate each harmlessly.
2. Invite one safe experiment. No roll for learning the rule. A risky crossing uses Athletics, a justified technical Trait, or another concrete approach.
3. State a modest failed-crossing cost before the roll. Pip, if present, explains that these laws belong to a real neighborhood.

If players exploit the painted door: Reward that creativity; don't change the rule to block them. **If Pip is absent:** A displaced resident provides the same truth. **End when:** The group understands the physics well enough to plan a rescue.

2B. Save the people on both sides (2-rescue)

Set the table: Show bus, escape route, boundary; mark 8 Task Tokens in 4 rounds and the six-box danger clock. **Say:** "You can stabilize this, but nobody can cover all three jobs alone."

1. Let each hero pick anchoring, evacuation, boundary work, or Support. Use Athletics, Repair, Electronics, or Persuasion when the narrated action fits. Deal task Action Cards and count tokens openly.
2. In round two, point to the falling sign *before* resolving damage. Moving people out of its zone prevents harm; otherwise Agility avoids 2d6 damage on failure.
3. Contractors arrive, **one per hero**, aiming to restrain Pip. Offer command-level negotiation, a distraction, or combat. A cooperative contractor can prioritize evacuation.
4. At the end of any round when **no one** addressed civilians, fill a danger box. At six boxes another group is stranded, still rescuable.

If the task fails: Civilians require a second response and property may be damaged, but the story continues. **If heroes attack contractors:** Use Extra profiles; survivors may surrender and still carry the records. **End when:** Rescue stabilizes or shifts to follow-up, and a contractor's premature knowledge is apparent.

2C. Follow the cleanup (2-paper)

Set the table: A discarded dispatch sheet has a Thompson routing mark and a timestamp before the emergency. **Say:** "The supplies arrived before anyone reported the damage."

1. Hand over **Handout 2** automatically from a worker, kit, or notice. Don't lock it behind a victory or roll.
2. Research verifies the timing; a raise reveals an additional matching contract. Failure means surveillance or bureaucratic trouble, not loss of the sheet.
3. Ask what the team does with helpful or hostile contractors. Record an ally or an opponent for Session 3.

If the party burns the document: A photo or public work order preserves the essential facts. **If they go straight to Thompson:** Let them learn its department name but keep the maze confrontation for when they have leverage. **End when:** The team knows that prediction, profit, and Thompson are connected.

Session 3: Shake the Snow Globe

Before play: Put three investigation options on one index card: records, depot, witness. Prepare Inez and Calder, plus the crew's contractor relationship. **Pacing:** investigation 45–60; outside shake 30–45; Calder 45–60. Award the second milestone Advance afterward.

3A. Offer three ways into the pattern (3-routes)

Set the table: Three leads are simultaneously available. **Say:** "You can follow the money, the equipment, or the people who were there. Where do you start?"

1. At records, Inez shares public invoices; Research adds a shell account. At the depot, workers show schedules; Stealth or Persuasion yields private manifest details. At a witness site, someone saw pulsing equipment; Electronics identifies the Thompson control destination.
2. Give the core pattern without a check at every route: repeated equipment serials and advance preparation. Checks win extra certainty, privacy, and leverage.
3. A failure costs time, discretion, or cooperation. Have the group choose whether to pursue a second lead or confront Calder.

If they split up: Cut between two brief scenes; don't punish the split with missing clues. **If they already distrust Inez:** Public records provide the same essential proof. **End when:** The common serial and Thompson destination are established.

3B. Show the hand outside (3-shake)

Set the table: A curved reflection catches the skyline as the whole city tilts. **Say:** "The horizon moves independently of the buildings. For a moment you can see a wall curving around all of Chicago."

1. Warn of a short shake; offer saving a stranger or preserving footage/equipment as visible priorities.

2. Use a normal appropriate Trait roll for a risky intervention. Success changes who is saved or what evidence is kept, not whether players recognize deliberate shaking.
3. If they miss the shot, a witness has a recording. If they don't intervene, make the civilian consequences concrete and recoverable.

If someone tries contacting the outside hand: Offer a distorted signal or pause in the motion, not a premature audience with the Keeper. **End when:** Everybody understands this is privilege exercised intentionally, not a routine malfunction.

3C. Confront the beneficiary (3-calder)

Set the table: Calder offers the heroes contracts and influence before reaching for an alarm. **Say:** "You're clearly capable. I could use people who solve problems rather than make speeches about them."

1. Ask whether they negotiate, expose, arrest, stalk, or attack. Roleplay his aim: preserve control over repair revenue and reach Thompson if cornered.
2. If a contested negotiation matters, use core Social Conflict. If he runs, use a short Chase. If captured or defeated, the key and documents still identify Thompson. Do **not** declare an automatic escape.
3. On any outcome, reveal that Calder was the human beneficiary, not the qualified external bidder. His phrase for the arrangement is "enrichment."

If Calder cooperates: Let him trade the route and one favor for protection. **If Calder dies:** A deputy's order preserves the destination. **End when:** Players choose how to enter Thompson, with Calder's fate recorded.

Session 4: The Thompson Center Maze

Before play: Place the five-node fictional map (A ticket hall; B departures; C records; D controls; E seam) beside you. Have Handout 3 ready, a four-box Maze Shift clock, and custodians at half the party count rounded up. **Pacing:** navigation 40–50; ledger 40–50; controls 45–60.

4A. Choose a route through jurisdiction (4-ticket)

Set the table: All three offices insist another office has jurisdiction. **Say:** "The ticket has been printed three different ways. Every counter says you are at the wrong counter."

1. Show A connecting visibly to B and C. Calder's key opens one node for free. At B, helping stranded travelers earns a transit badge and path to D. At C, a clerk offers an estate ledger.
2. Let a roll save time, prevent suspicion, or win a shortcut. Never roll for finding the other route. Mark one shift box for repeated unchanged tactics or an accepted delay.
3. At four boxes send custodians, one per two heroes rounded up; they warn, can negotiate, and can retreat.

If they bypass offices: Reward an imaginative route into D or C while still delivering the ledger. **If they get lost:** An embarrassed clerk points them to C. **End when:** They can distinguish buyer and beneficiary.

4B. Make the deal legible (4-ledger)

Set the table: The public ledger names Up's estate, the Keeper's bid, and Calder's benefit. **Say:** "Chicago appears under estate inventory. There is no line for the consent of its residents."

1. Give **Handout 3** without a roll. Answer plainly: Up died in an accident, the estate sold the inhabited holding, and the Keeper acquired shaking rights.
2. Invite questions and ethical reactions. Research or Persuasion can find a severance record or a procedural weakness, but not a hidden murder plot.
3. If the team tries legal remedies, let them suspend one shake or free a custodian. Complete severance still needs the physical seam or an equally substantial table-developed alternative.

If they try to sue the estate: Make the hearing a chance to earn an injunction or access, not an endless dead end. **If they reject legal procedure:** The seam diagram is still obtainable. **End when:** The group decides whether to disable the shake system or race straight to the seam.

4C. Choose what to disable (4-seam)

Set the table: At D sits a shake switch; at E is a diagram of the ownership seam and a route to fictional Loop Resonance Works. **Say:** "Turning off the tremors buys people time. Breaking the seam would end the claim itself."

1. Offer two active problems: disabling the local shake feed (Electronics, Repair, or plausible physical action) and securing the seam diagram. The diagram is visible even on failed rolls.
2. On success, record *first accelerator hazard prevented*. On failure, cost a tool or introduce a custodian; do not erase the diagram.
3. Give Calder any ending the players earned: captured, bargaining, surrendered, or gone. Clarify the beam cracks ownership without transporting Chicago.

If players propose demolition: Let them understand who is at risk, and offer targeted feed isolation as an option. **If they depart at once:** They still know where to go. **End when:** Each hero names one thing or person they intend to protect during the firing.

Session 5: Crack the Bottle

Before play: Draw fictional Loop Resonance Works with three feeds and two exits. Prepare a 12-token/4-round task, six-box Earthquake clock, two rift leeches, and contractors equal to half the crew rounded up. The machine is imaginary: no real accelerator engineering needed. **Pacing:** arrival 30–40; activation 60–90; earthquake and separation 35–50.

5A. Reach the fictional test hall (5-arrive)

Set the table: Dr. Vale shows power, calibration, containment, and a crowded evacuation corridor. **Say:** "You have one shot at the seam, but not everyone here knows what's about to happen."

1. Ask each hero to choose a concrete role: power, calibration, containment, evacuation, or defense. Dr. Vale answers questions but does not operate the mission for them.
2. Apply the Thompson switch choice. If disabled, the first hazard is a warning. Otherwise announce a falling panel at a service exit; Athletics or Repair can protect that route.
3. Establish visibly that the beam targets a supernatural ownership seam, not real infrastructure or citizens.

If the team refuses to fire: Let them plan evacuation or seek alternatives; don't trigger the task until they commit. **If Mark is absent:** Other power sources and technical choices remain viable. **End when:** The team has assigned roles and states its firing conditions.

5B. Activate under pressure (5-fire)

Set the table: Start 12 Task Tokens over 4 rounds; put the earthquake track next to it. **Say:** "Four cycles to align the seam. Every cycle makes the floor less trustworthy."

1. Resolve a SWADE Dramatic Task with Action Cards. Electronics runs power/calibration, Repair contains, Athletics braces, Persuasion coordinates civilians. Support applies normally and earns no independent tokens.
2. Add two leeches in round two; narrate the visibly blocked feed. In round three contractors equal to half the heroes rounded up arrive unless an ally kept them away.
3. Add one earthquake box every activation round. Before a risky containment action warn that a Critical Failure adds an extra box, then use core task consequences as well.
4. Track participation, task progress, and exposed civilians openly. Do not make Dr. Vale solve an unattended role.

If combat runs long: Keep initiative for threats but preserve the four task rounds as announced. **If the crew is underpowered:** Offer civilians and allies as Support, never free victory tokens. **End when:** The firing attempt resolves.

5C. Choose a cost and let the world open (5-break)

Set the table: The seam strains while the ground cracks. **Say:** "The city can stay here. The boundary may not survive. What do you save first?"

1. If the task succeeded, sever the seam. If it failed, offer an emergency firing that works but damages the hall and fills the earthquake track; **do not force acceptance**. Refusers can retreat, repair a portable feed, and retry later.
2. At six earthquake boxes, warn exposed heroes about debris and give Agility to reach cover; failure deals 2d6 damage. A prepared evacuation saves civilians automatically.
3. When the boundary breaks, describe Chicago remaining in Chicago while the heroes are ejected to a service platform outside. Show the platform's auction plate as potential vessel material.

If someone sacrifices equipment or leverage: Make it matter in Session 6. **If they seek to stay in Chicago:** Give them a concrete choice and consequence before departure; don't seize their characters by fiat. **End when:** The surviving travelers see the primordial sea and decide how to travel.

Session 6: Adrift in the Universe

Before play: Show three possible stops (stranded train, elven departures, auction dock) and a six-box Slide Departure clock. Ready **Handout 4**. Two stops make a satisfying gathering, but allow a different itinerary.

Pacing: vessel 45; two stops 65–85; timed crossing 35–50.

6A. Build a way to travel (6-vessel)

Set the table: The auction platform floats above a strange foggy sea. **Say:** "You have material for a boat, a route instrument, and an astonishing amount of nowhere. What kind of vessel can this crew build?"

1. Have players name its shape; then ask how it gets power, steers, and reads a route. Each part needs a suitable successful Trait roll; Support is welcome.
2. A missed roll creates a repair beat or a limitation (slow speed, noisy drive, fragile hull). Never destroy the vessel outright before travel starts.
3. Give **Handout 4** and connect its signal to a Chicago location the group previously named. Mark may power a part but cannot make all the choices.

If they want to walk or fly: Use the same three functional needs for their proposed travel method. **If no materials remain:** The platform itself has detachable plates, cable, and bolts. **End when:** The crew names its vessel and chooses the first stop.

6B. Choose two stops, not a tour checklist (6-islands)

Set the table: Show three destinations on separate index cards: train, departures, dock. **Say:** "Each harbor offers a route home, but none of them will hold still forever."

1. At the **train**, rescuing passengers costs two travel beats and wins a signal lamp; leaving costs one beat and leaves someone in need. At **departures**, two custodians demand a badge; negotiate, use the ledger, evade, or fight for a route stamp. At the **dock**, search one beat for spare anchors and refuse or negotiate a reposessor shortcut that would renew a claim.
2. Run each stop with one or two justified Trait rolls or a Quick Encounter. Show consequences first. Reset the six-box slide clock when arriving at a new stop.
3. Any **one** lamp, stamp, or anchor identifies the home route; **two** grant +1 on the finale's first calibration. Don't require visiting every island.

If they invent another port: Reskin a listed opportunity and cost without erasing the essential direction. **If they accept the reposessor's offer:** Record the promised ownership claim explicitly. **End when:** A plausible signal home is in hand and the next opening is visible.

6C. Leave before the slide closes (6-cross)

Set the table: Display six departure boxes and describe an opening visible across the sea. **Say:** "You have a short window. The vessel needs someone to steer and someone to hold the anchor."

1. Require one navigation and one anchoring check using sensible Traits. Other heroes can Support, guard, or deal with a visible obstacle.
2. Fill the clock after meaningful travel beats, including extra repairs and rescues. At six, the current slide closes; the crew can wait with one new cost or take another offered route.
3. If both anchors are lost, show a catchable cable or an allied tow immediately. This is a perilous detour, not campaign-ending limbo.

If the group tries the wrong opening: Describe the landmark discrepancy before locking the decision; let them back out at a price. **If they choose to wait:** Provide a tangible repair, rescue, or resource challenge. **End when:** Everyone knows the home signal and can see the final approach.

Session 7: Message in a Bottle

Before play: Prepare 8 Task Tokens over 3 rounds, a four-box Final Tether clock, the reposessor's Wild Card stat block, and the Chicago place chosen for the signal. Recall whether the team gained two travel preparations.

Pacing: message 35–45; confrontation 60–90; epilogues 35–50. The ending should belong to the table, not a preset cutscene.

7A. Make home recognize them (7-message)

Set the table: Chicago is too far away to see; a familiar place offers a route signature. **Say:** "Someone on the other side can help, but they need to know where to look. What do you tell home?"

1. Ask every hero for one line of the message, and one meaningful job sending or stabilizing it.
2. Establish the named Chicago location and a signal of **three long flashes and one short**. Electronics, Repair, Persuasion, or justified methods send it. If the crew earned two travel preparations, the first calibration attempt gets +1.
3. Mark, if an NPC, supplies current while the heroes choose the destination. If the lamp is missing, use visible cable and a repair beat.

If someone has a better encoding idea: Accept it if it identifies the same chosen place. **If they distrust help at home:** Ask what person or memory the signal should reach; don't require named NPC survival. **End when:** Home answers and the reposessor reveals its claim.

7B. Resist the last claim (7-claim)

Set the table: An unmistakable tether attaches to the vessel. The reposessor politely offers safe passage in exchange for restoring the ownership boundary. **Say:** "I can guarantee your return. The terms are exceptionally reasonable, provided the city remains secured."

1. Put the tether's terminal visibly within reach. Announce choices: bargain, fight, delay, cut, or break the terminal. Electronics or Repair disables it at -2; the exposed terminal has Toughness 6. Defeating the reposessor is not required.
2. Start the 8-token/3-round Dramatic Task for alignment and crossing. Each hero chooses between contributing, Support, and addressing the tether. Use Action Cards and SWADE task rules.
3. Fill one Final Tether box after each finale round while the attachment remains. At four boxes the agent boards, but the terminal remains removable and the exit possible.

If players take the bargain: State the cost in plain language and record acceptance; do not present it as freedom. **If they defeat the agent early:** Keep the tether as a technical objective until severed. **End when:** The task and tether states are both known.

7C. Resolve the crossing, then listen (7-home)

Set the table: Resolve two independent facts: did the party align home, and is the Keeper's tether disabled?

Say: "You can see home. What did your choices cost, and who is waiting?"

1. **Task succeeds, tether disabled:** Free return. **Task succeeds, tether active:** The bow reaches Chicago but the vessel stays held; residents help while the crew gets a final opportunity to sever the terminal or force release.
2. **Task fails:** The window closes onto an anchored island. Offer a visible repair and next-cycle retry, with a damaged vessel or delayed homecoming as the cost. **Bargain accepted:** Return with ownership compromised, naming that problem openly rather than declaring victory.
3. Invite each player to narrate one changed relationship, one place visited first, and one promise for the future. Give the final line to a person or place the heroes saved.

If they refuse an ending you anticipated: Ask what concrete step they take next, use the established mechanics, and let their chosen outcome stand. **End when:** Players, not the GM, have described what freedom and homecoming mean for their characters.

One-page handoff between scenes

At the end of every scene, jot: **who is safe, what changed, what clue is now known, what cost was paid, who is now an ally or adversary, and which two next actions are visible.** If a clue is unclear, restate it in the fiction before the next roll. A failed roll changes leverage or pressure, not access to the only path forward. Between gatherings, update the heroes' chosen Chicago anchor, Calder's fate, Pip's trust, the status of workers and custodians, the portal frame, any repaired vessel, and whether the final tether/bargain remains outstanding.

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